

Simulated CPG PO Automation Case Study

Fictional portfolio scenario created to demonstrate workflow design, KPI thinking, automation readiness, and operational leadership.

Privacy Note: This document uses fictional company names, sample scenarios, and synthetic metrics. It is designed to demonstrate strategic thinking, analytics, workflow design, and leadership approach without disclosing confidential employer or customer information.

SCENARIO

Northlake Foods Distribution is a fictional regional CPG distributor supporting grocery and specialty retail customers. The company receives purchase orders through multiple inboxes and portals, then manually assigns work to order-entry staff. The process is functional but inconsistent: duplicate orders appear, task ownership is unclear, aging is hard to see, and leadership lacks a clean view of workload risk.

BUSINESS PROBLEM

- POs arrived through multiple channels without one reliable intake queue.
- Duplicate notifications created repeated tasks and unnecessary rework.
- Order aging was tracked manually, making escalation late instead of proactive.
- Task status lived in individual memory instead of a shared operating system.
- Leadership could not quickly see volume, exceptions, aging, owner workload, or service risk.

DESIGNED SOLUTION

Layer	Design choice	Control benefit
Intake	Dedicated Outlook folder triggers a structured PO intake flow.	Creates a single source of entry without forcing staff to change email habits all at once.
Tasking	Planner task created with PO number, customer, received date, due date, owner, and source link.	Work becomes visible, assignable, and easier to supervise.
Tracking	Excel/SharePoint table records each PO as an auditable row.	Supports dashboarding, aging formulas, dedupe checks, and trend analysis.
Dedupe	Flow checks recent PO numbers and customer combinations before creating a new task.	Reduces duplicate work and prevents inflated workload reporting.
Governance	Status values, aging bands, exception reasons, and owner fields are standardized.	Allows consistent coaching, escalation, and management review.

SAMPLE KPI FRAMEWORK

KPI	Definition	Why it matters
On-Time Entry %	Percent of POs entered within target service window.	Shows whether the workflow is keeping pace with customer needs.
Aging Risk Count	Open POs older than defined threshold.	Creates early warning before missed deadlines pile up.
Exception Rate	Percent of POs delayed due to missing info, item issues, pricing questions, or access problems.	Separates staff productivity issues from process or upstream data problems.
Duplicate Avoidance	Potential duplicate tasks blocked or flagged.	Protects team capacity and improves reporting accuracy.
Owner Load Balance	Open task count and aging by owner.	Supports fair workload distribution and coaching conversations.

OPERATING RHYTHM

- Daily: review new intake, blocked items, aging risk, and duplicate flags.
- Weekly: review owner workload, exception trends, service performance, and process defects.
- Monthly: summarize top friction points, automation defects, dashboard improvements, and team training needs.
- Quarterly: revisit KPI thresholds, business rules, and whether the workflow still matches the actual work.

SAMPLE OUTCOME MODEL

Because this is a simulated case study, the figures below are illustrative and not based on any employer system. A realistic outcome model would target improved visibility, fewer duplicate tasks, faster escalation, cleaner staff accountability, and better management reporting. The real win is not a fancy automation; it is giving the team a shared operating truth.

Before	After design
PO status dependent on email memory and manual follow-up.	PO status visible by owner, aging, and exception reason.
Duplicate notifications created rework.	Dedupe logic flags repeated PO/customer combinations before work is assigned.
Escalation happened after delays were already painful.	Aging bands identify risk while there is still time to act.
Leadership had fragmented visibility.	Dashboard summarizes intake, backlog, exceptions, and service performance.

TRANSFERABLE VALUE

This simulated project demonstrates the same leadership muscles needed in sales operations, customer success operations, retail execution, and transformation roles: define the problem clearly, avoid overbuilding, protect adoption, measure what matters, and make the process easier to manage.